

1. It had more accurate data about customer demand because it was observing real customer behavior, not asking hypothetical questions.
2. It put itself in a position to interact with real customers and learn about their needs. For example, the business plan might call for discounted pricing, but how are customer perceptions of the product affected by the discounting strategy?
3. It allowed itself to be surprised when customers behaved in unexpected ways, revealing information Zappos might not have known to ask about. For example, what if customers returned the shoes?

Zappos' initial experiment provided a clear, quantifiable outcome: either a sufficient number of customers would buy the shoes or they would not. It also put the company in a position to observe, interact with, and learn from real customers and partners. This qualitative learning is a necessary companion to quantitative testing. Although the early efforts were decidedly small-scale, that did not prevent the huge Zappos vision from being realized. In fact, in 2009 Zappos was acquired by the e-commerce giant [Amazon.com](https://www.amazon.com) for a reported \$1.2 billion.²

For Long-Term Change, Experiment Immediately

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Corporate guidelines encourage every employee to spend up to four hours a month of company time volunteering in his or her community; that volunteer work could take the form of any philanthropic effort: painting fences, building houses, or even using